

Q How many daytime naps should my baby have? Will it prevent him from sleeping at night?

In general, you should be aiming to let your baby have three naps during the day to make sure he does not get overtired. He will probably get himself into a pattern of taking a nap in the morning shortly after he has woken up and been fed, another nap at lunchtime, and then a third nap late afternoon. The third nap should not be too close to bedtime or he might struggle to fall asleep later. It is also important to make sure he does not sleep too much during the day, since this can affect the quality of his nighttime sleep. As he grows, he will start dropping his naps, usually the late afternoon nap goes first.

Q What is a good bedtime routine for my young baby and is it too early to try to establish one?

After six weeks, as part of helping him learn the difference between day and night, it can be helpful to set up a regular bedtime routine. Following the same steps every bedtime means your baby will become familiar with the routine, and in turn associate the process with bedtime. If you follow the same pattern every night, your baby will feel safe and secure, and learn to differentiate between daytime naps and bedtime. A relaxing bath, followed by a long feeding, and a story will help your baby unwind. Even if you just point out the pictures, your baby will love hearing your voice and having

your undivided attention. If your baby is really tired, a bath will revive him to allow him to have a good feeding before bed. Many parents find this a special time of day when they share quiet cuddling with their baby.

Night-lights can trick your baby's brain into perceiving daylight and awake time. Try using a red lightbulb instead (which our brains don't see as daylight) to find your way during night feedings.

Q What is SIDS and how can I prevent it? Are there any key risk factors?

There are several steps you can take to keep your baby safe while he sleeps. Most important is that you are always in the same room as your baby while he is asleep.

Very rarely, a baby dies in his sleep, known as Sudden Infant Death syndrome (SIDS), or crib death. While the causes still aren't completely understood, there are a number of factors that have been shown to increase the risk of SIDS significantly, and the greatest risk occurs in the first six months of life. Low birth weight and premature babies, as well as male infants, are also more at risk.

PRECAUTIONS AND PREVENTION

The following will help to ensure that your baby sleeps safely:

» **Put your baby down** to sleep on his back with his feet at the very end of his crib ("feet to foot") so that he can't wiggle down under bedding.

» **For the first six months**, it is safer to put your baby to sleep in a crib or bassinet in the same room as you.

» **Avoid pillows**, baby duvets, and soft toys in the crib for at least the first year.

» **Keep the room temperature** where your baby sleeps around 60–68° F (16–20° C).

» **Don't smoke** near your baby, or allow anyone else to. Never sleep in the same bed as your baby if you have smoked, drunk alcohol, or taken drugs or medication that makes you drowsy.

» **If possible, breast-feed** your baby. There is a lower incidence of SIDS in breast-fed babies.

» **Never sleep on a sofa or chair** with your baby.

» **Using a pacifier** (after one month if you're breast-feeding) may reduce the risk of SIDS.

Safe sleeping
Your baby must always be placed with his feet at the end of his bassinet or crib, and always on his back.

